something in the tone of that made Tom apprehensive.

'Yes'm. That is, I believe they do.'

'You do?'

'Yes'm.'

The old lady bent down and took the teaspoon and held it out! Tom winced and dropped his eyes. Aunt Polly raised him by the usual handle – his ear – and cracked his head soundly with her thimble.

'Now, sir, what did you want to treat that poor dumb beast so, for?'

'I done it out of pity for him - because he hadn't any aunt.'

'Hadn't any aunt! – you numbskull. What has that got to do that with it?'

'Heaps. Because if he'd had one she'd burnt him out herself! She'd a roasted bowel out of him 'thout any more feeling than if he was a human!'

Aunt Polly felt a sudden painful regret. This was putting the thing in a new light; what was cruelty to a cat might be cruelty to a boy too. She began to soften; she felt sorry. Her eyes watered a little, and she put her hand on Tom's head and said gently:

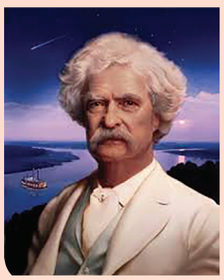
'I was meaning for the best, Tom. And, Tom, it did do you good.'

Tom looked up in her face with just a recognisable twinkle peeping through his gravity.

'I know you was meaning for the best, aunty, and so was I with Peter. It done him good, too. I never see him around so since'

'Oh, go 'long with you, Tom, before you annoy me again. And you try and see if you can't be a good boy, for once, and you needn't take any more medicine.'

About the Author



Samuel Langhorne Clemens (1835-1910), better known by his pen name Mark Twain, was an American writer, humourist, entrepreneur, publisher and lecturer. Twain was raised in Hannibal, Missouri, which later provided the setting for his novels. His famous works are The Adventures of Tom Sawyer and The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn.

Glossary

infatuated (v) : inspired with an intense but short-lived passion or admiration for someone or something

plunges (n) : act of casting or thrusting forcibly or suddenly into something liquid

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